INSPIRE

Women's Edition



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The Women's Edition of *Inspire* is a dedicated to writing about strong, empowering women, whether it is their accomplishments or the programs that come from their memory.

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ABOUT THE AUTHORS



NEEKA EGHBALI is a junior Public Relations major with a minor in Professional & Technical Writing and a cognate in Marketing & Advertising. Her goal is to become an Account Executive or Creative Director at a PR or advertising agency. Neeka has worked as a Peer Career Advisor at Virginia Tech Career & Professional Development for the past two and a half years and is a sister of Kappa Kappa Gamma. She is also a member of the Department of Communication's Undergrad Advisory Committee, offering advice to improve the Department's offerings. In her spare time, Neeka enjoys being outside, hanging out with friends or reading a good book.



CHLOE ROGERS is a sophomore Multimedia Journalism major with a minor in Professional & Technical Writing at Virginia Tech. Her goal is to be a journalist and work in visual media. Chloe is a certified yoga instructor and has been practicing for three years. In her spare time, she enjoys hiking, going to concerts and trying new foods.



MADDIE THOMPSON is a junior Multimedia Journalism major with a minor in Professional & Technical Writing and a concentration in Sports Media Analytics at Virginia Tech. Her dream job is to be a television broadcast producer at a news station or work for a sports media outlet like ESPN. Maddie currently works as a tutor at the Virginia Tech Writing Center as well as at the student run newspaper, *The Collegiate Times,* where she is head sports editor. She is passionate about writing and journalism as well as her favorite Washington D.C. sports teams.



ANNA PENDLETON

NEEKA EGHBALI
Designer

For some, taking stunning photos with a professional DSLR camera is a tremendous feat. For Anna Pendleton, it's an art; almost second nature.

Pendleton is a natural-light portrait photographer from Richmond, Virginia. She is a strong advocate of storytelling and is dedicated to take on any challenge in order to convey a special moment in time for her clients. Some of the memories she captures are of seniors graduating, families, couples, weddings and a wide array of other topics.

While she photographs almost any event, Pendleton is also a full-time student about to graduate from Virginia Tech with a double major in public relations and Spanish. She is an active member of the Public Relations Student Society of America (PRSSA), a pre-professional society for aspiring PR practitioners.

In this organization, Anna served as Vice President this past year. She also served as Director of Publications during the 2016-17 school year, in which she was able to use her creative eye for design to produce the semester newsletter, *The Medium*.

Pendleton had the opportunity to study abroad in Spain in her Spring 2016 semester of college. The trip made her realize even more how much she loved Spain's language and culture.

Recently, Pendleton got a new camera, a Canon 80D. "I like it because it's really fast and has a lot of focal range," she said. Anna's love for photography, design and public relations has led her to become a NEXTern this summer at Padilla, a top ten independent PR and communications agency, in Richmond.

Becoming a NEXTern allows budding PR professionals to participate in the agency's summer internship program, offered to college students and recent graduates.

It is no surprise that Pendleton has been so successful in her college career. President of PRSSA, Jordan Hogge, worked closely with her for the past year and had nothing but great things to say.

"Working with Anna has been nothing short of amazing. She is such a genuine person and I honestly don't think I would have made it through the semester without her. She is always willing to go the extra mile and is so fun to be around," said Hogge.

She continued, "It amazes me how on top of balancing school, PRSSA and Chi Omega how she also has her own side photography business. She's so incredibly talented in all areas and I'm so thankful to be able to call her my friend. Every day Anna continues to inspire and amaze me!"

Now, Pendleton is excited for the next chapter of her life: her career. The past four years of college have been leading up to this moment, and Pendleton is ready to take it on while remembering to stop and capture the memories, camera in hand.

[Q&A] WITH ANNA &

Q: How has being president of Chi Omega shaped who you are, and how have you shaped other young women in this organization?

A: Being president of Chi Omega has been a wonderful experience, it has allowed me to develop new confidence and taught me to stand firm in what I value and believe in most. I hope that I have instilled this confidence in others and helped empower younger women in Chi Omega.

Q: How long have you been a photographer and how long have you been photographing grad pictures? What do you enjoy most about being an entrepreneur?

A: I started taking photography my freshman year of high school and have stuck with it since! I started taking grad pictures in high school when all my friends were graduating and have continued to do so through college. I love being able to capture and share memories and love being able to offer a service that people truly enjoy.

Q: What do you believe a strong woman looks like?

A: Strong women are confident in themselves and what they believe in. They build other women up and strive to make the world better in some way.

Q: How have your experiences in PRSSA and public relations as a whole affected you? Have you been exposed to stereotypes in this field and if so, what do you want people to know?

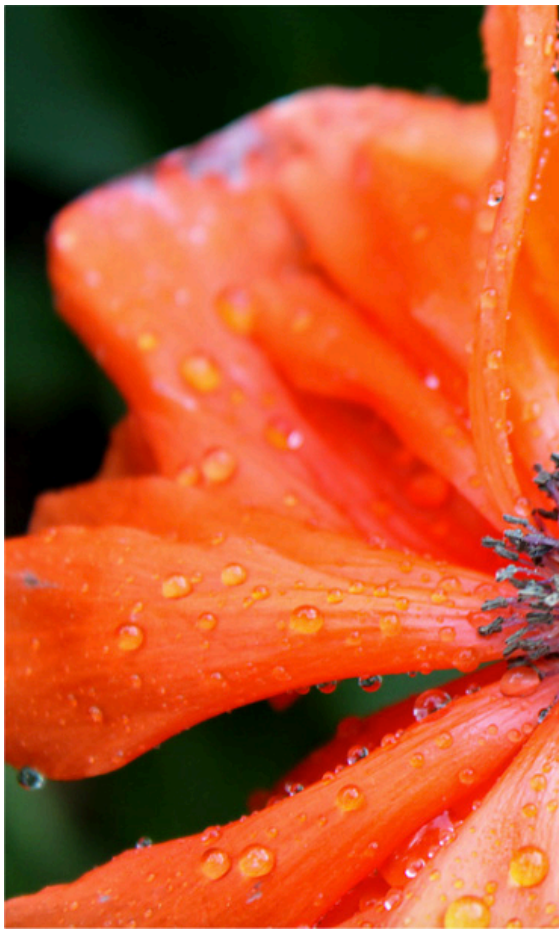
A: PRSSA and PR have allowed me to develop professional skills that have prepared me for life after graduation. I have not been exposed to many stereotypes fortunately but I do want women to feel confident and able to complete any career they want to.

Q: Where do you see yourself in five years?

A: I'm not entirely sure where I see myself in five years but I hope to be working a job I love and still keeping up with other hobbies and things that are important to me.

Q: What do you believe is the best way to empower young women like yourself?

A: I think the best way to empower young women is to allow them the opportunity to lead and to try and make a difference. Until you start trying to be empowered and try to empower others, you will never know what you can accomplish!

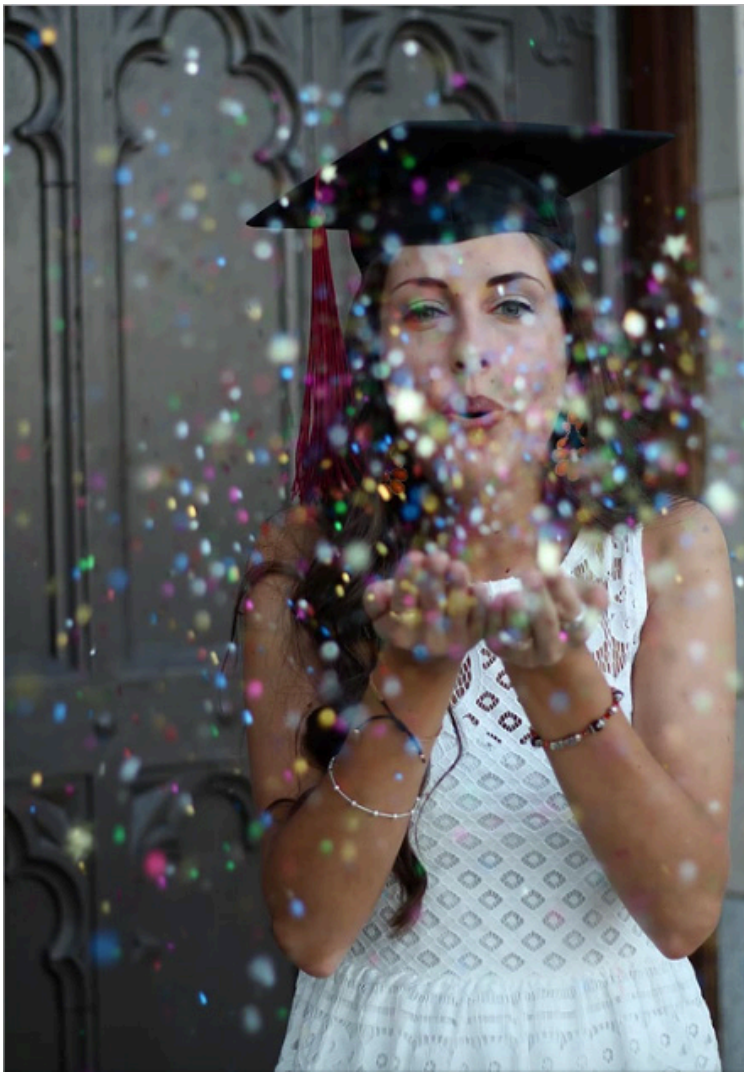


& A POTFOLIO SNAPSHOT











ALPHA CHI OMEGA

MADDIE THOMPSON
Designer

Women for Women:

Virginia Tech sorority focuses its efforts on advancing awareness of domestic violence and methods to combat it

A junior studying Public Relations, Kate Avdellas didn't think she would ever know the ins and outs of what domestic violence looked like when she entered college. Now an executive member of her sorority, Alpha Chi Omega, she knows more about the topic than she ever thought she would, and more specifically, what it takes to recover from and prevent it.

Each Greek organization commits to a certain philanthropic cause, Alpha Chi Omega's being raising awareness and funds to battle domestic abuse and violence. Locally, the sorority raises money to fund the **Women's Resource Center of the New River Valley (WRC)**. Through events and food drives, 100 percent of everything raised goes to help with the Center's day-to-day operations.

Established in 1997, the Women's Resource Center of the NRV provides several services to women who are escaping abusive situations. Most recently, with the help of a block grant from the Virginia state government, the Center was able to build transitional housing for those women that need a place to live while they get back on their feet.

During fundraising events, a week dubbed "Mock Rock", from this past fall, Alpha Chi Omega was able to collect enough food and goods to supply the Center for a whole year, a feat that Avdellas is still pleasantly stunned by.

"I think the craziest thing is to see how much food we can collect in such a short amount of time," she said, smiling.

Mock Rock has gotten so large that the director of the Women's Center visits the chapter during their week of fundraising to discuss what kind of an impact the organization has on them. Avdellas says that with a cause like domestic



violence, collecting food isn't the only goal.

"Domestic violence is something that unfortunately occurs way too often and is something no one talks about," said Avdellas. "I think [Alpha Chi Omega's] philanthropy is crucial because it forces people to talk about it, and also shows survivors, our fellow Hokies that we care and are there for them."

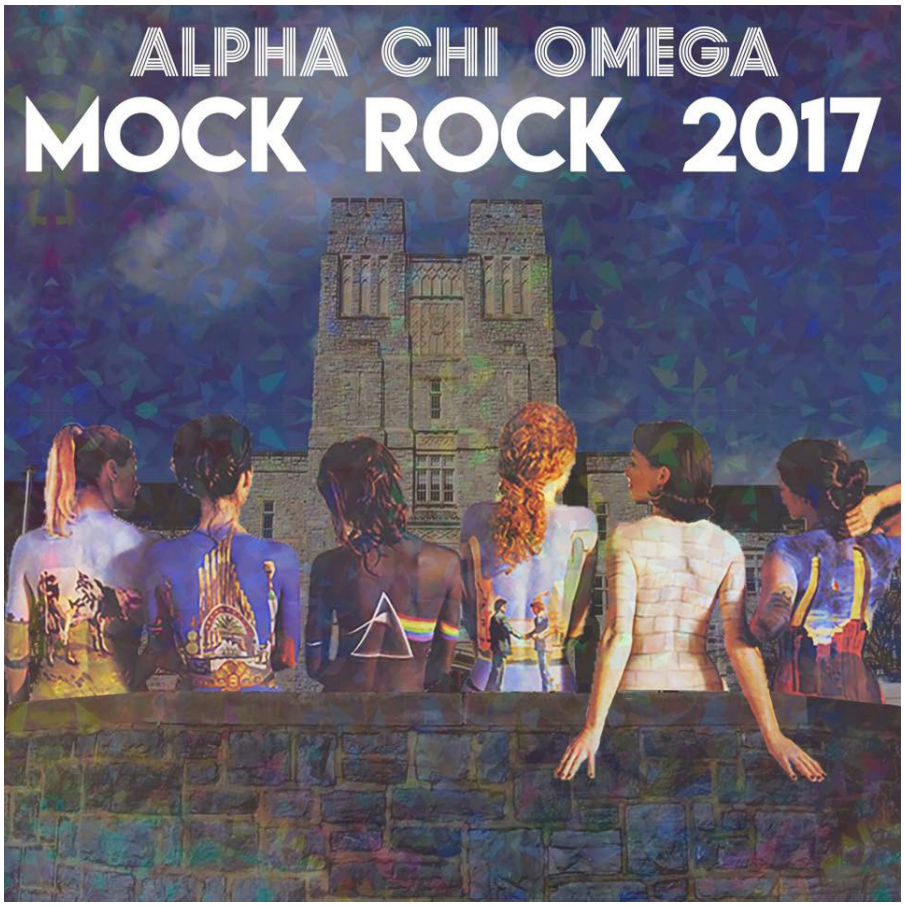
On Virginia Tech's campus specifically, there is a similar resource, called the **Women's Center of Virginia Tech**. It is funded by the university, and offers several different services to faculty, students and staff. Though not as extensive as the WRC of the New River Valley, it offers similar resources for those living around Virginia Tech's campus. The Women's Center is a much newer establishment; it was created in 1994.

Avdellas, who didn't know much about the Women's Resource Center before she joined Greek life, wants that to change for those that come to Tech or live in the New River Valley. Her hope is that through the efforts of Alpha Chi Omega, as well as those of people who live in and around the New River Valley, the WRC can become a well-known place of solace for struggling women, and be a thriving resource for the area.

"[The Women's Resource Center] is a safe place for victims no matter how little or small," she says. "The Women's Resource Center can help anyone and get them back on track to an amazing life."

"The Women's Resource Center can help anyone and get them back on track to an amazing life."

Kate Avdellas,
Alpha Chi Omega
member







KEVIN PEI

CHLOE ROGERS
Designer

A sophomore at Virginia Tech has figured out how to make an awful tragedy into a beautiful cause. After his girlfriend Torey, another fellow Virginia Tech student, took her own life in February after a long battle with depression, Kevin Pei knew he needed to do something to honor her. With this came the inception of the Eden Resource Center.

Torey was a huge advocate for women's empowerment, especially regarding gender-based violence, sexual assault and domestic abuse. She was a volunteer at the Women's Center at Virginia Tech, working to help with awareness campaigns and aimed to be a gynecologist someday. Kevin decided to honor Torey's life and legacy by starting a GoFundMe on his birthday for donations towards the Women's Resource Center of the New River Valley. His original goal was $1,000. They raised $5,621, enough for 21 emergency outreach visits following assaults.

Following this success, Kevin decided to start the Eden Resource Center. During Torey's battle with depression, he saw the ins and outs of how depression and anxiety affects someone, as well as the obstacles and difficulties in receiving proper treatment and preventative measures in a timely manner.

"Things need to change. We have to start focusing on proactive measures rather than reactive."

Kevin's goal for the Eden Resource Center is to provide direct, reliable and comprehensive information on wellness resources in the New River Valley, especially regarding mental health.

The ERC is primarily intended for Virginia Tech students, specifically targeting freshman, who tend to go through a lot of mental health issues due to the drastic transition to the "real world," Kevin said. The ERC also hopes to eventually expand to NRV high schoolers and other nearby students.

"For many people who step into counseling, they've already had to endure so much pain and suffering. So why not try to stop the issues before they happen?" Kevin said.

"People should not have to scroll through pages and pages of link after link, or spend time, money and efforts on resources that ultimately do not work well for them."

The ERC also has plans to integrate a women's health branch and hopes to work with the Women's Center at Virginia Tech and other female-support organizations such as SAVES, "to collaborate on campaigns and projects promoting mental health from a female perspective."

"Down the line, we also want to share and spread awareness of the mental health consequences of gender-based violence and sexual assault," Kevin said.

Kevin is from Arlington, VA and is double majoring in Industrial & Systems Engineering and Psychology. He is a lover of Olympic weightlifting and coaches CrossFit classes at Virginia Tech in his free time. He is very interested in the public health and wellness industry, and hopes to work in Healthcare Engineering someday.

{Q & A}

Q: What inspired you to start the Eden Resource Center?

A: The journey of my girlfriend Torey trying to get mental health services, as well as her suicide, inspired me to start the ERC. Since Torey's passing, I have been incredibly driven to make a difference in the wellness industry, especially with mental health.



Kevin's girlfriend Torey, a Virginia Tech student, who passed away in February - her middle name is Eden

Q: Can you tell me what the Eden Resource Center is, who the center is intended for and what inspired you to start it?

A: The Eden Resource Center ultimately strives to be a one-stop shop for information and suggestions on wellness resources in the NRV. But as of now, we're just focusing on mental health. I have personally witnessed the process of seeing Torey try to get the help she needs, and I have personally experienced it as I tried to get support through my grieving process. That being said, I've seen that the process of receiving effective health services is unnecessarily indirect. People should not have to spend so much time, effort, and resources just to find something that doesn't work. The primary goal of the ERC is to direct students to health resources and services that are compatible to their needs and situations. To do so, we will have direct information on each service, comparing them. Some of our other goals involve eliminating the stigmas around mental health, so students may seek to prevent these issues from arising. Typical health services put significant effort on a reactive approach, rather than a proactive one. We also want to bring more student organizations together to be a unified voice for change on campus. We are planning to work with Active Minds, Division of Student Affairs, Hokie Wellness, service fraternities, and several other wellness organizations as well.

with Kevin

Q: Who is the center intended for?

A: The ERC is primarily intended for Virginia Tech students, specifically targeting freshman, who tend to go through a lot of mental health issues due to the drastic transition to the "real world". We would love to eventually expand to NRV high schoolers and other nearby students.



Q: What are your future plans for the Eden Resource Center?

A: My future plans are to connect to more student organizations to recruit ERC team members ad to simply promote our cause. Virginia Tech has so many passionate individuals, we just need to bring them together and find those willing to help with the ERC. With an increase in awareness and workforce, I will be able to delegate significantly more, and the ERC will be able to expand its influence. We also plan to integrate a women's mental health part of the ERC in the future. We hope to work with the Women's Center and other female-support organizations such as SAVES, to collaborate on campaigns and projects promoting mental health from a female perspective. Down the line, we also want to share and spread awareness of the mental health consequences of gender-based violence and sexual assault.

EDEN

The Eden Resource Center's official website will launch fall 2018. Follow them on their Facebook page @ EdenResourceCenterNRV and Instagram @edenresourcecenter.